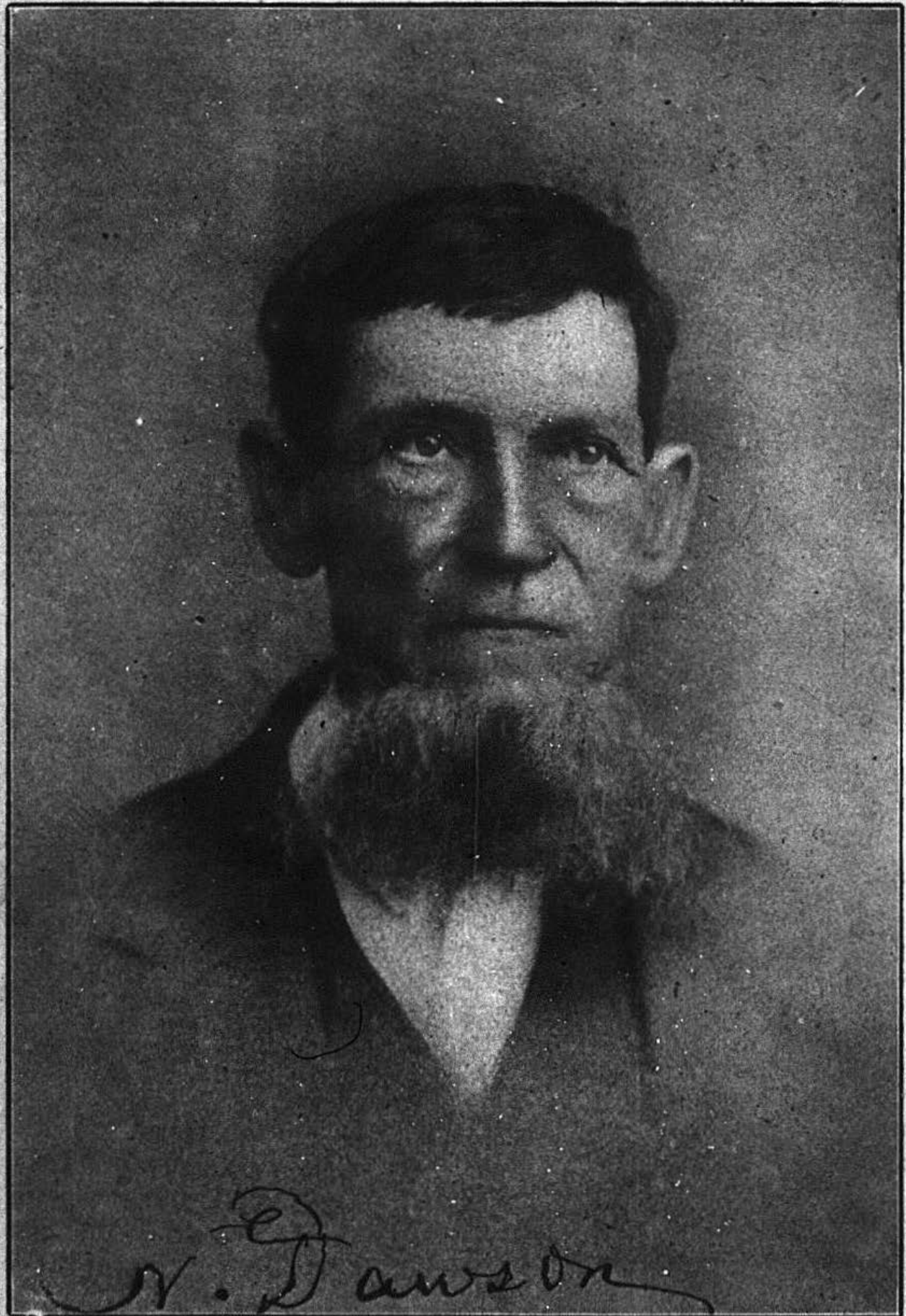




W. Dawson

CALIFORNIA IN '41.

"

IN '49

Trip One

" Two

TEXAS IN '51.

MEMOIRS.

BY

NICHOLAS DAWSON.

"Cheyenne Dawson"

(1901)

PREFACE.

The following narrative was commenced by me on the first of March, 1894—fifty-three years after the occurrence of the principal events narrated—and was written mostly from memory, but with an anxiety to say only the truth; and if any errors have been made they were unintentional. My object in writing was to gratify my children, and leave to them the outline of my rather eventful life.

NICHOLAS DAWSON.

carters to haul the lumber to the beach, or to oversee hands stacking it up. The credit system was in vogue, and my greatest trouble was to keep from selling to slow-pay customers, and to collect from them when sold to; for very little honor was to be found in either natives or foreigners.

CHAPTER IV.

OTTER HUNTING ON THE SANTA BARBARAS.

Some of Dye's shipments to the islands proving unremunerative from the great waste in handling such brittle lumber, he closed out the business at Santa Cruz. * He decided to try otter or seal hunting, and invited me to join him. Our outfit consisted of three boats, similar to whale boats, and was made by Dye himself. They were clinker built, some fifteen feet long, and carried three men each: the hunter on the front seat, with three rifles and a paddle; a hand in midship with a paddle; and a steersman behind, with a paddle and a mast and sail to use when desired. We took provisions and ammunition in the boats.

Setting out with Dye as hunter in one boat, I in another, and a man by the name of Simmons in the third, we coasted from Monterey down to

Santa Barbara, and out to and around Santa Rosa and San Miguel Islands, killing a few otter.

Our mode of procedure was this: We traveled by sail or paddle to a place where otters were known to be found, and waited for a favorable day. Very few spots suitable for camps were found. There must be fresh water, and a place where the boats can land through the surf without capsizing. We often ventured to land at spots where it was risky. This we did by approaching and waiting for a big roller; then, by vigorous strokes—the steersman keeping her bow straight on—we would go in on top of it, and be sent so far up as to give time to unload and carry boat and all up out of the reach of succeeding billows.

The otter were found lying on the kelp with only the head in sight, and always in bunches, or schools. They are shot in the head, and can best be hunted when the water is still. Approaching noiselessly and placing our boats so that the otter were in the center, we would begin the battle, loading and firing rapidly until the otter were all scattered. Then, picking up our game, we would give chase to one of the runaways. Here the difficulty was in keeping track of the game, as they travel under the water and only come to the surface for breath. The hunter has

seen the direction of the dive and paddles in that direction, ready to fire when the otter's head comes above the surface. The chase is kept up until the otter is killed or the trail lost; then if no other otter can be started, the hunt is up; and as soon as skinning, fleecing, and drying is through with, a travel is made to another locality.

Otter hunting is a very exciting business, and somewhat dangerous, as you are apt to think when you hear a bullet whistle past you, it having glanced from a wave as it came from a hunter's gun opposite, who had shot at an otter on a line between you and him. But these risks will be run for an otter skin, worth thirty dollars, and especially when there is rivalry among the hunters.

At Santa Barbara we found an old otter hunter, A. B. Thompson, who had formerly been in the business with vessels and Alaska Indians, and who proposed to go into partnership with us on the halves—he to furnish a vessel officered and manned, and to provision us; we to furnish boats, guns and ammunition and do the hunting. His offer was accepted; and two Santa Barbara hunters, Sparks and Nydever, joined in with us, making, with Dye, Simmons and myself, five boats. The advantage in having a vessel was that with water and provisions on board the hunters could

be lowered at any point, the vessel cruising around until we got through, and in this way places inaccessible for boats could be hunted.

We first visited San Nicholas Island, and, hunting around it, killed several otter. Here we searched on shore for a lone woman whom we knew to be on the island, but failed to find her, although we found her tracks. Why she was there I had best explain:

Such of the Santa Barbara Islands as had fresh water on them had once been inhabited by a low type of Indians, who eked out a miserable existence by fishing for and eating shellfish. Some were induced to emigrate and join the missions, but a remnant remained, and these being about to perish from starvation, an effort was made, headed by the priests, to have them all transported to the mainland. A vessel was sent, and at San Nicholas, after all were on board, this woman, from some freak, jumped overboard and swam ashore. A southeast storm coming on, the captain made sail without further search. (Since that time I have seen an account of her rescue by George Nydever and Charley Brown, both of whom I knew. They found her while they were on an otter hunt, and carried her to the mainland, where she soon died from overeating.)

On the brig Bolivar, we hunted all points along Lower California to Ceros Island, then, otter giving out, we abandoned the hunt and beat back against headwinds to Santa Barbara. Here a general division and settling up was effected, and I found myself with forty dollars in money and five or six otter skins, a broken arm, and my feet so badly bruised that I could scarcely walk on crutches.

My physical condition happened in this way: The vessel had dropped us on the island of Ceros to hunt, if favorable weather intervened, while she made further search below for otter. The weather continuing boisterous, part of us set out to traverse the island on foot. Soon after we left camp I, in order to get a shot at some spotted seals, ventured too near the brink of a projecting point. My feet flew up, I could find nothing to grasp, and I went over. But I yelled, gave my gun a cast that it might fall flat, and straightened my legs under me to lessen the shock. I do not know how far I fell, but when I came to, my comrades were around me, I was on a bed of sand, and all around were big rocks detached from the cliff above. On examination it was found that my left arm was broken, and my feet and legs so bruised that I could not walk. One man went

back to camp for a sail, from which a litter was made, and I was carried to camp. Dye attempted to set my arm, but it remains till now a little crooked, and weaker than the other. My feet and ankles, though bloodshot for awhile, in time became as so'und as ever.

CHAPTER V.

ACROSS MEXICO, AND HOMEWARD BOUND.

By this time, I thought I had seen enough of California, but the difficulty now was how to get away. In the meantime I took board with a Mexican lady in Santa Barbara, and waited.

From A. B. Thompson, the owner of the brig we had used in otter hunting, I learned that the government schooner would be dispatched soon to Mazatlan, with a messenger and dispatches; that she would not land at Santa Barbara, but would stop at San Pedro, where she was to take on the messenger, Pio Pico, of Los Angeles; that a vessel of Thompson's would be going down in a few days on which I had better take passage to San Pedro, there to await the schooner. This I did, and stayed with Don John Foster, at San Pedro ranch, until the schooner came down.